CINEMA

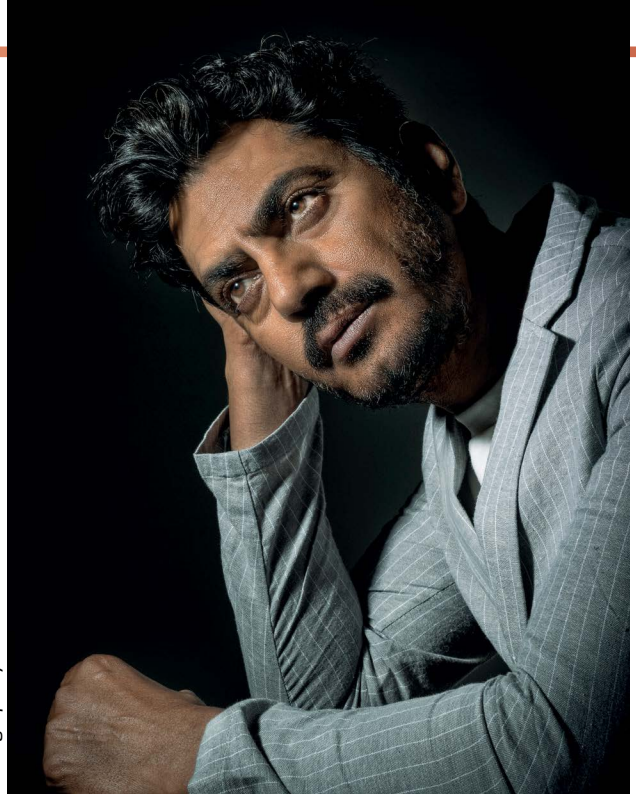
Fifty Shades of Prejudice

The Indian film industry is still no place for the darker-skinned actors

By **SUHANI SINGH**

It's not just actresses who face colourism in the film industry. Actor Nawazuddin Siddiqui has spoken up about how "more than nepotism", the industry is afflicted by "racism", as a result of which talented actors are overlooked for meaty parts and offered tertiary roles instead. Casting calls seeking "fair-skinned" actors, particularly for the female parts, are still too frequent. Bollywood actors may have learned their lesson in not endorsing fairness products after sizeable backlash, but the industry's portrayal of dark-skinned characters continues to be narrow-minded and stereotypical. Even its attempt to advocate against discrimination of dark-skinned people misfired as happened in *Bala* (2019) when actress Bhumi Pednekar was brownfaced for the part.

In her paper, 'The Brownfaced Bollywood: An Analysis on the Presentation of Dark-Skinned Characters in Bollywood Films', Riya Varghese, a student at the School of Media Studies at Chennai's Loyola College, looked at three 2019 Hindi films—*Bala*, *Gully Boy* and *Super 30*—to conclude that dark-skinned people "are often depicted as a weak, malnourished, subaltern class". Varghese also pointed to the 'gendered colourism' in cinema, which leads to dark-skinned women faring worse than dark-skinned men. And while a dark-skinned actor could well be paired with a light-skinned female



Photograph by BANDEEP SINGH

ACTOR NAWAZUDDIN SIDDIQUI (ABOVE) HAS SPOKEN UP ABOUT HOW "MORE THAN NEPOTISM", THE INDIAN FILM INDUSTRY IS AFFLICTED BY "RACISM"

began to push male skin lightening products. In a departure from the 'tall, dark and handsome' trope of the West, Fair and Handsome, as a male fairness cream was called, was promoted as a desirable attribute, a fundamental trait for male attractiveness.

Fairness creams of yore are passe, a whole range of specialised serums, masks and body products now promise an even skin tone, reduction of hyperpigmentation, even reversing your age. Beauty parlours now offer not just plain fruit facials and bleaches, they have become 'clinics' now, offering laser and chemical solutions to your skin 'problems' (see *The Beauty Bazaar*). Fairness is also no longer about the face, there are also whitening options for even the armpits and the vagina.

TOWARDS SKIN POSITIVITY

So where do we go from here? The needle may be moving, even if ever so slightly. "Certainly, activism around beauty norms and how they stigmatise people and damage them psychologically has resulted in a welcome expansion of beauty-related products and services globally," says Parameswaran. Inclusion has become a buzzword in the beauty lexicon, the catwalks have become exemplars of diversity. Barbie now has darker-skinned versions in an attempt to normalise dark skin, while theatre and cinema are finding roles and a place for Black and brown actors. Dark is now divine and brown is beautiful. Pivoting to the new reality, companies have come up with exclusive make-up for the darker Indian skin tone. Ghazal Alagh, co-founder & Chief Innovation Officer of Honasa Consumer, which has brands like Mamaearth, The Derma Co. and Bblunt as part of its portfolio, says, "When we started Mamaearth, we made a conscious decision to not create or market products that promise fairness. Instead, we focused on healthy, well-nourished skin. Inclusivity also meant challenging the visual representation in beauty advertising. From day one, we ensured we featured real, diverse Indian skin tones in our campaigns." At FAE Beauty, there is a strict policy against filters and Photoshop. "We don't want to propagate unrealistic body standards and want consumers to see things just as they are. Our content is raw, unfiltered," says